

ANI

**FESTOONED FIGURES**
CM Basavaraj Bommai (centre) with BJP leaders at a Jana Sankalpa rally

Bommai brings up the reservation extension as a sign of the party's commitment to social justice. "The demand had been there for 50 years, but we acted on it," he told a gathering in Yadgir on October 19. The government has brought in an ordinance to implement the 6 per cent hike, but legally it is a tricky proposition, since Karnataka has already hit the 50 per cent ceiling set by the Supreme Court.

Over the years, the BJP has been successful in winning over a section of SC groups such as the Madigas, who had moved away from the Congress. Despite the increase in the reservation limit, however, an equally long-pending demand by these groups for fixing internal quotas still remains a minefield.

Meanwhile, BJP state general secretary N. Ravikumar says the BJP's original voter base is intact. Bringing back Lingayat strongman BSY into the thick of things—the 79-year-old was appointed to the BJP's parliamentary board in August—was a move towards securing that. In Karnataka, the coastal, Malnad and central districts are the BJP's Hindutva bastion while its Lingayat community support extends across the northern districts. The Hyderabad-Karnataka region—officially renamed Kalyana-Karnataka in 2019 when BSY was chief minister—refers to seven districts in the northeastern part of the state with a sizeable Lingayat and Dalit population. Bommai is showcasing his government's welfare schemes such as education scholarships for farmers' children and free power for SC/ ST families to woo them.

"We are getting very good response for our rallies," says Ravikumar. The Jana Sankalpa rallies will be held in 150 assembly seats—three teams of BJP leaders will cover these constituencies by January, with a focus on as many as 67 seats currently held by the opposition. Of the latter, the main focus is on the Hyderabad-Karnataka and Old Mysore regions, besides Bengaluru city.

The Old Mysore region comprises the southern districts where the party has traditionally been handicapped. Here, the biggest voting bloc is the Vokkaliga community, and H.D. Deve Gowda is their big leader. The BJP, however, is making a strong bid to woo the community. The unveiling of a 108-feet-tall statue of Kempe Gowda, the founder of Bengaluru and a Vokkaliga icon, by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on November 11 will be part of this.

"If we have to come back with an absolute majority, we have to do better in the Hyderabad-Karnataka and Old Mysore region. Things are looking up," says the leader quoted earlier. With elections just six months away, it's anyone's game in Karnataka. ■